Why do young Americans support redistribution?

Survey evidence on a widening U.S. age gap

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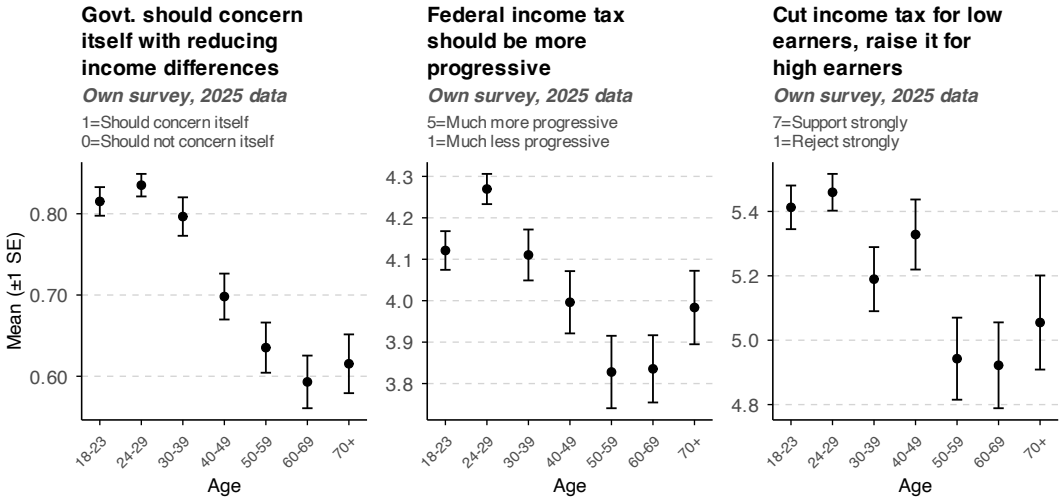
Why do young Americans have different preferences?

If the election were held today, how would you vote on Proposition 40, the one-time tax on billionaires?

POLITICO / Citrin Center (UC Berkeley) / TrueDot poll of California likely voters, fielded October 9–14, 2026

	Age			
	18–29	30–44	45–64	65+
Yes	64%	62%	44%	28%
No	18%	25%	49%	63%
Undecided	18%	12%	6%	10%
N (unweighted)	68	226	314	301

Current age gap on income redistribution



Life Cycle vs Beliefs?

Two competing hypotheses:

- Lifecycle: currently low income + time discounting, present financial stress, long-term career/lifestyle risk, prospect of upward mobility.

  Largely *self-interest*-driven.
- Belief divergence: experienced inequality, growth, mobility, housing prices, social safety net access, diversity, immigration. Shaped by political narratives and the supply of politicians/platforms.

  Largely *belief*-driven.

Summary of findings

1. It is not the economic position of the young: 26 measures of income, risk and prospects explain none of the gap.
2. It is what the young believe about the economy: zero-sum and deservingness beliefs account for much of the gap.
3. The age gap on redistribution grew from zero in the 1970s–80s to +0.5 SD today (half of the party gap, similar to the race gap, double the gender gap).
4. A similar age gap in beliefs has emerged.
   - Ongoing analysis: what drives these beliefs?

Our survey

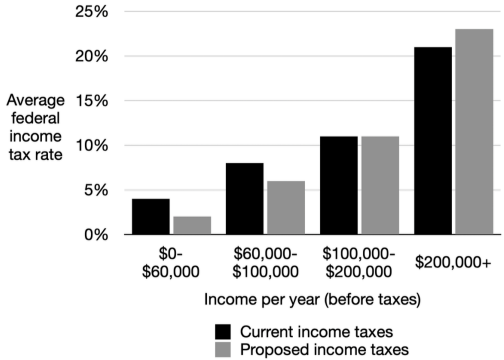
- Online survey of U.S. citizens, fielded on Prolific in spring 2025.
- $N = 2,415$, one half 18–30, one half > 30.
- 15 minutes on average, 92 questions.
- Covers current financial position, history, expectations, risks, beliefs about the economy, and values.

Questions asked

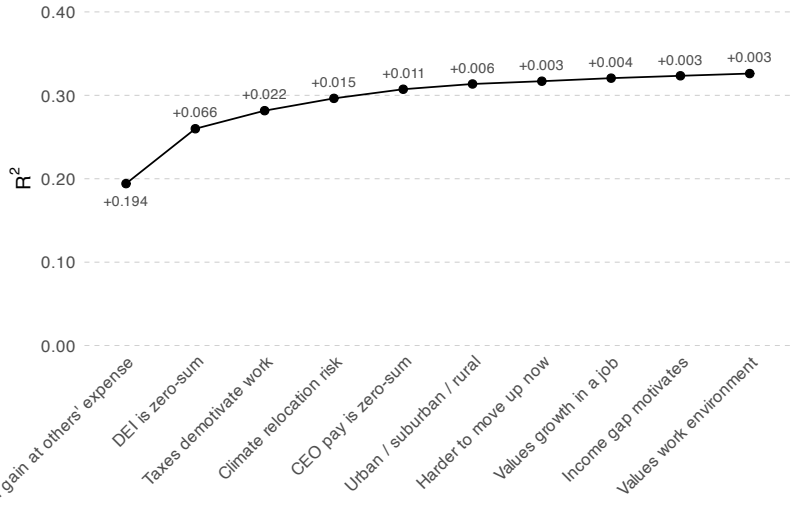
- Policy preferences: income redistribution (3), why preferences changed (2), alternative policies to support low-income (5).
- Economic position: current and expected income (12), future income needs (5), financial insecurity (4), AI/climate/housing/health risk (4), family/personal history (5), ambitions (5).
- Beliefs: incentive effects of taxation (2), zero-sum beliefs (4), mobility (4).
- Values: time discounting (7), generosity/universalism (2), materialism (2).

Core outcomes

1. Should the government concern itself with reducing income differences between rich and poor people?
2. Should the federal income tax be more progressive than it is now (redistributing more income from the rich to the poor)?
3. *Description of revenue-neutral tax.* Would you support or reject the proposed change?



Strongest correlates: forward selection



2

Strongest correlates from forward selection

Should the government concern itself with reducing income differences between rich and poor people?

Own survey, 2025. OLS, outcome and items in SD units; the ten items the add-one-in selects first.

Question	Alone	All ten
People usually get rich at the expense of others rather than by creating value for others.	+0.44	+0.22***
DEI initiatives create opportunities for some at the expense of others.	-0.38	-0.18***
If taxes on high incomes are increased and taxes on low incomes are decreased, people will not work as hard.	-0.33	-0.12***
What is the risk that you have to relocate due to climate events in the next 10 years?	+0.23	+0.11***
Large gains in CEO and executive salaries have been at the expense of the salaries of average workers.	+0.39	+0.12***
Would you consider your current location urban, suburban, or rural?	+0.10	+0.08***
Is it harder or easier to move up in the U.S. now than when your parents were growing up?	-0.26	-0.06***
Rank of "opportunities for growth and advancement" among five things valued in a job.	+0.00	-0.08***
A large income gap is needed to motivate entrepreneurs to start businesses and innovate.	-0.30	-0.07***
Rank of "a good work environment and colleagues" among five things valued in a job.	-0.05	-0.05**
R^2		0.33
N = 2,415; standard errors 0.017–0.022; * p<0.05, ** p<0.01, *** p<0.001		

Strongest corrlates: Shapley decomposition

Should the government concern itself with reducing income differences between rich and poor people?

Own survey, 2025

Question	% of R^2
People usually get rich at the expense of others rather than by creating value for others.	16.6%
DEI initiatives create opportunities for some at the expense of others.	13.9%
Large gains in CEO and executive salaries have been at the expense of the salaries of average workers.	12.1%
If taxes on high incomes are increased and taxes on low incomes are decreased, people will not work as hard.	9.1%
A large income gap is needed to motivate entrepreneurs to start businesses and innovate.	6.2%
— 83 questions with <5% omitted —	
Full model $R^2 = 0.37$, $N = 2{,}415$	

What accounts for the gap: Gelbach decomposition

Should the government concern itself with reducing income differences between rich and poor people?

Own survey, 2025

Question	Contribution	% of explained
People usually get rich at the expense of others rather than by creating value for others.	-0.037	43.7%
DEI initiatives create opportunities for some at the expense of others.	-0.019	22.3%
Rank of "opportunities for growth and advancement" among five things valued in a job.	-0.014	16.3%
What is the risk that you have to relocate due to climate events in the next 10 years?	-0.010	12.2%
— 65 questions with <10% omitted —		
Age gradient: bivariate -0.211, with all covariates -0.126		40.4%
N = 2,255		

Discussion: is it zero-sum or deservingness?

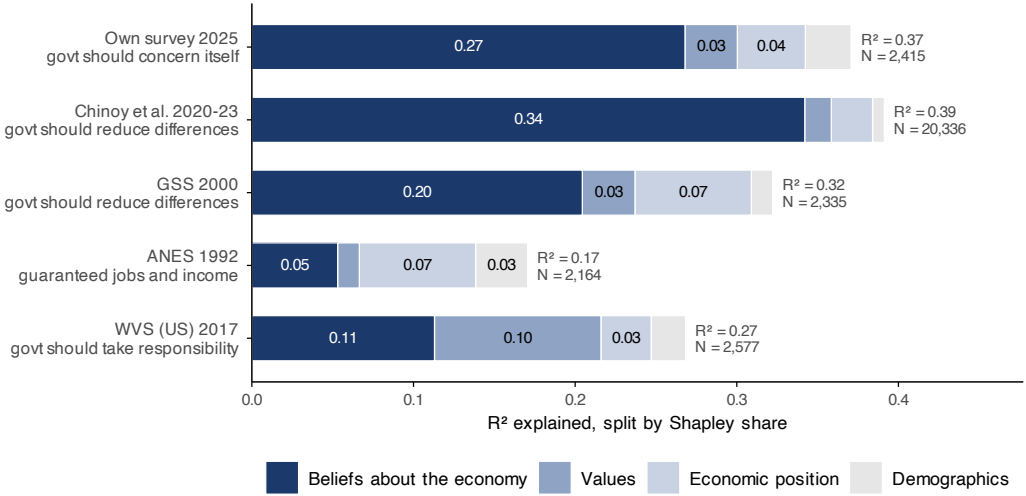
Related but distinct beliefs

- Positive-sum vs zero-sum: whether one's effort can grow the pie or one's gains are necessarily another's losses.
- Attribution/deservingness: whether one's gains were deserved or earned unfairly.

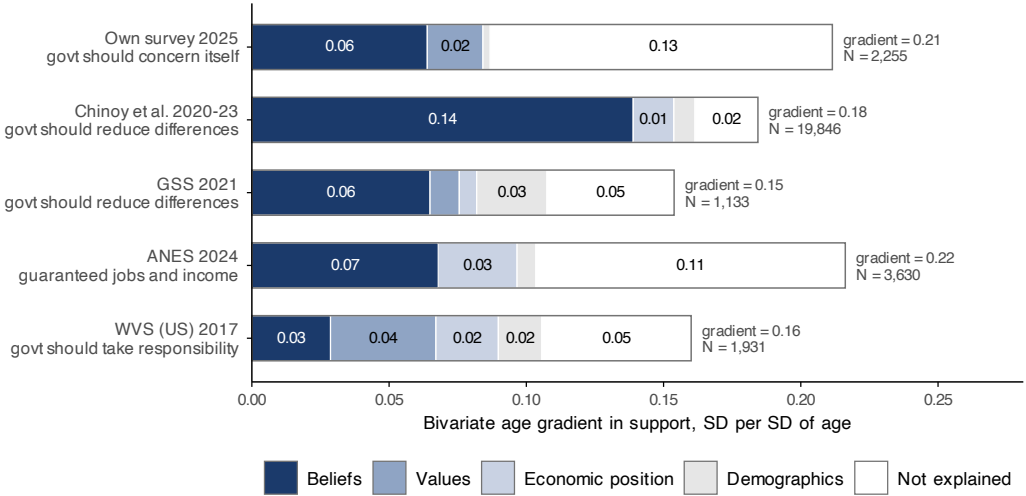
Observations

- Young people on average believe that CEOs are zero-sum but not DEI initiatives; zero-sum is not a universal belief.
- "Tax demotivates" and "gap motivates" address positive-sumness and predict preferences but have no age gap.

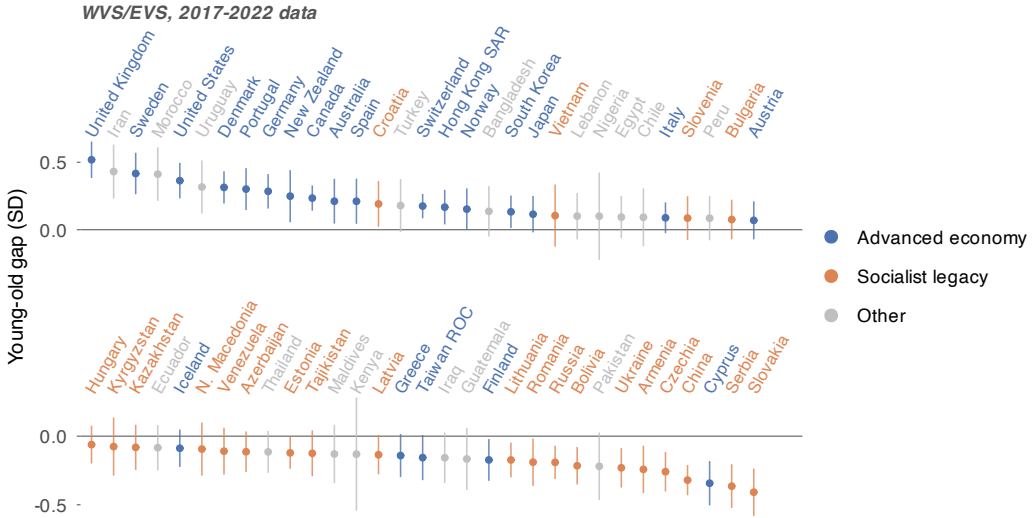
Comparing to other surveys: strongest correlates



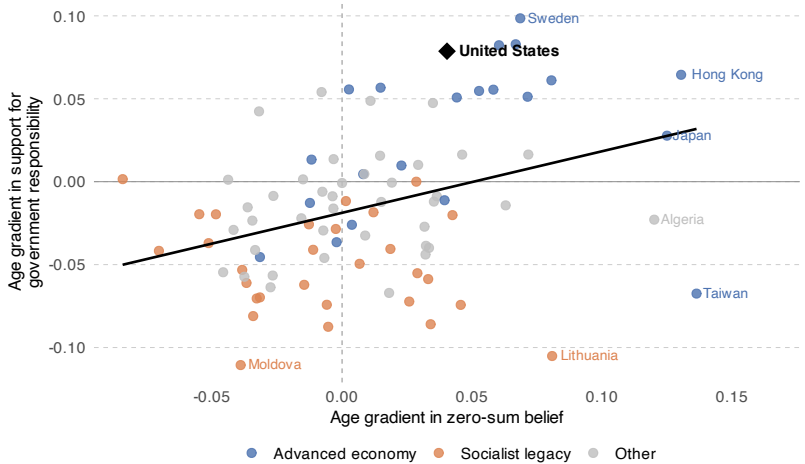
Comparing to other surveys: what accounts for the age gap



Age gap across countries



Redistributive vs. zero-sum age gradient across countries



Slope 0.37, r = 0.36, 91 countries (WVS). Each axis: within-country slope on age, SD of the item per decade; positive = the young hold the view more.

Zero-sum beliefs and redistribution within countries

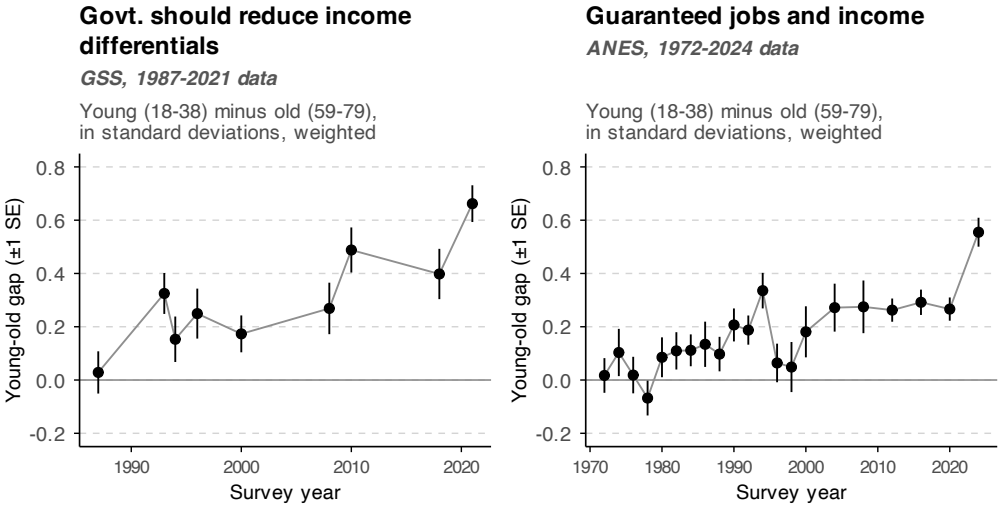
Individual-level WVS: redistribution on zero-sum belief

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
A. Incomes should be made more equal (E035)				
Zero-sum belief (E041)	0.117***	0.118***	0.107***	0.108***
	(0.010)	(0.010)	(0.008)	(0.008)
Within R^2	0.014	0.015	0.012	0.013
Observations	236,885	236,885	236,885	236,885
B. Government should take more responsibility (E037)				
Zero-sum belief (E041)	0.075***	0.075***	0.068***	0.069***
	(0.010)	(0.010)	(0.009)	(0.009)
Within R^2	0.006	0.006	0.005	0.005
Observations	238,268	238,268	238,268	238,268
Country FE	Yes	Yes		
Country × wave FE			Yes	Yes
Age control		Yes		Yes
Countries	92	92	92	92

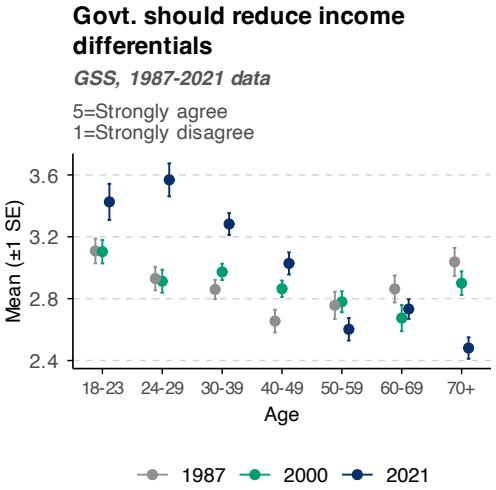
WVS waves carrying E041 (1990–2014), ages 18–79, weighted, SEs clustered by country. Items z-scored over the estimation sample (SD of the outcome per 1 SD of zero-sum); age control is age in decades. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Items on a 1–10 scale.

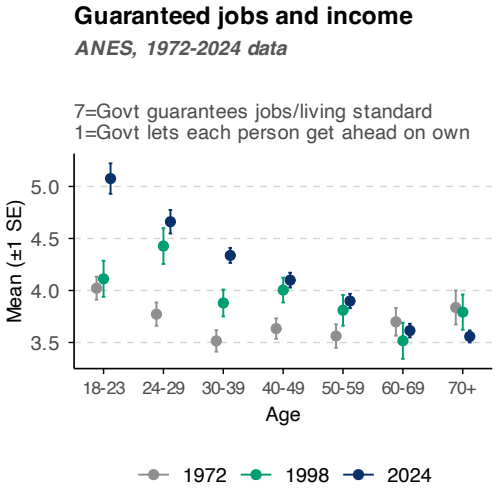
- E035: 1 = "Incomes should be made more equal" ... 10 = "We need larger income differences as incentives" (coded + = pro-equality).
- E037: 1 = "People should take more responsibility" ... 10 = "The government should take more responsibility" (coded + = pro-government).
- E041: 1 = "People can only get rich at the expense of others" ... 10 = "Wealth can grow so there's enough for everyone" (coded + = zero-sum).

Young-old age gap increasing over time

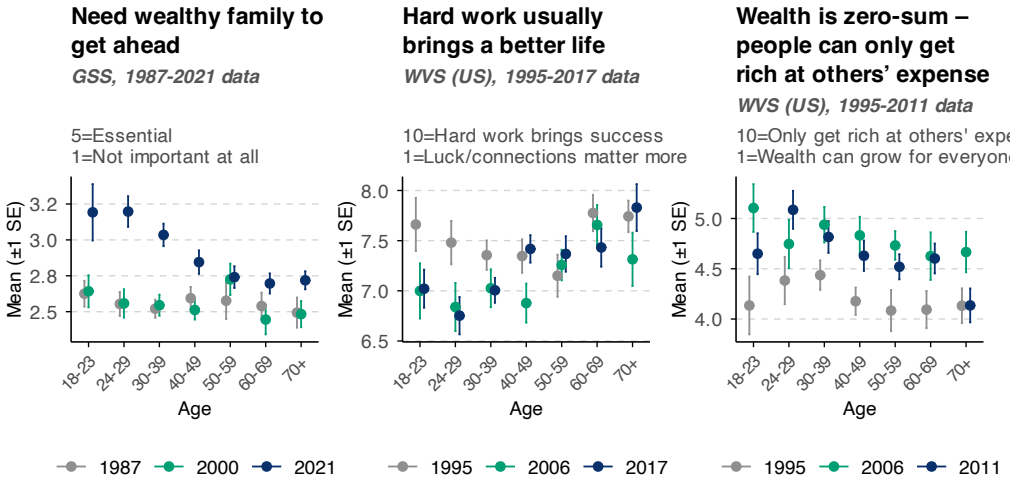


Cross-sectional age gradient steepening over time

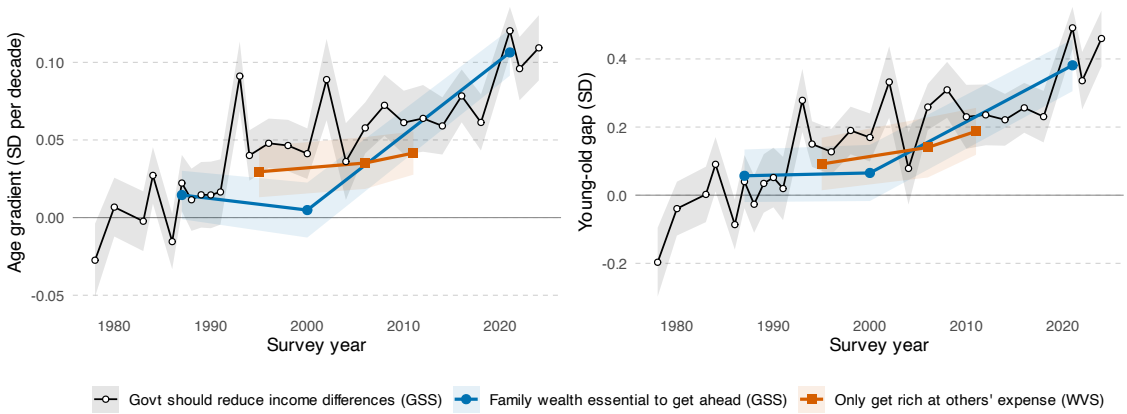




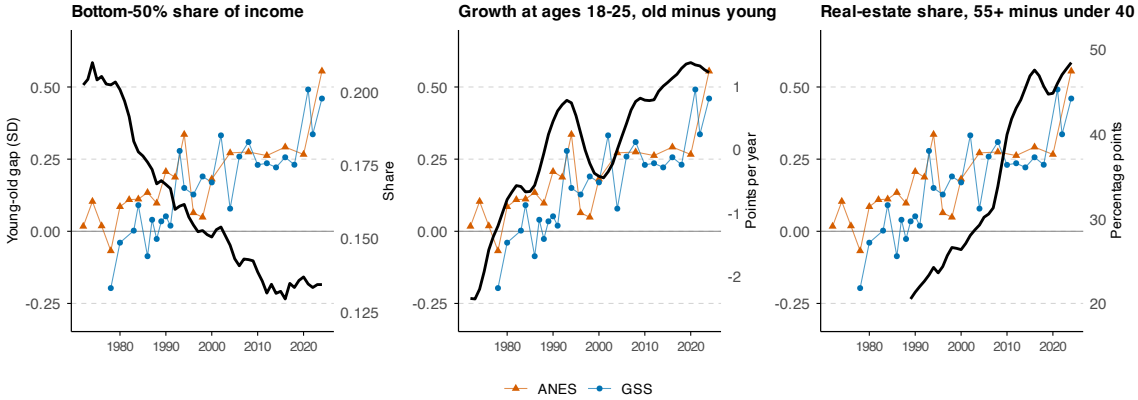
Steepening age gradient in zero-sum and deservingness beliefs



Redistribution and belief gaps over time



Inequality, growth, housing and the age gradient



Real estate: share of US household real estate held by households aged 55 and over minus the share held by those under 40, in percentage points (Federal Reserve Distributional Financial Accounts, quarterly from 1989). *r* uses its annual mean.

Formative-years growth and redistribution

Prolific 2025: support for redistribution on home-state formative-years income growth

Dependent Variables:		Reduce income differences			More progressive taxes	Support redistributive proposal
Spec.:	0–20	18–25	0–20, +age	0–20, +coh.		0–20
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Variables						
Formative growth, ages 0–20	-0.281***		0.082	0.028	-0.143***	-0.152***
	(0.045)		(0.059)	(0.071)	(0.043)	(0.042)
Formative growth, ages 18–25		-0.002				
		(0.026)				
Age			-0.019**			
			(0.009)			
Age^2			4.21×10^{-5}			
			(0.0001)			
Fixed-effects						
Home state	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)				Yes		
Fit statistics						
Observations	2,231	1,802	2,231	2,231	2,231	2,231
R^2	0.03980	0.02467	0.07179	0.10113	0.02824	0.02554

Clustered (Home state) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.150	–	–	–	−0.077	−0.081
as % of the young–old gap	57%	–	–	–	55%	61%

Formative-years growth: movers only

Prolific 2025, movers only (home state $\neq$ current state): support for redistribution on home-state formative growth, with and without current-state FE

Dependent Variable:	Reduce income differences			
Current-state FE:	No	Yes	No	Yes
Age controls:	No		Yes	
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Variables				
Formative growth, ages 0–20	-0.338***	-0.312***	0.032	0.071
	(0.071)	(0.079)	(0.108)	(0.117)
Age			-0.030	-0.024
			(0.021)	(0.022)
Age^2			0.0002	9.08×10^{-5}
			(0.0002)	(0.0003)
Fixed-effects				
Home state	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Current state		Yes		Yes
Fit statistics				
Observations	673	672	673	672
R^2	0.07756	0.17744	0.10692	0.20350

Clustered (Home state) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.198	−0.183	–	–
as % of the young–old gap	70%	64%	–	–

Absolute mobility and redistribution

Prolific 2025: support for redistribution on home-state absolute mobility

Dependent Variables:	Reduce income differences			More progressive taxes	Support redistributive proposal
Spec.:	home FE	+age	+coh.		home FE
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Variables					
Absolute mobility (SD)	-0.113***	-0.077	-0.303*	-0.031	-0.060**
	(0.034)	(0.091)	(0.164)	(0.044)	(0.028)
Age		-0.036			
		(0.028)			
Age^2		0.0003			
		(0.0002)			
Fixed-effects					
Home state	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)			Yes		
Fit statistics					
Observations	998	998	998	998	998
R^2	0.04822	0.04990	0.09092	0.04996	0.04385

Clustered (Home state) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.113	–	–	–	−0.060
as % of the young–old gap	43%	–	–	–	45%

Formative-years growth relative to the nation

Prolific 2025: support for redistribution on state−national formative growth

Dependent Variable:	Support for redistribution			
Spec.:	0–20	18–25	0–20, +age	0–20, +coh.
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Variables				
State−national growth, ages 0–20	0.021		0.036	0.028
	(0.174)		(0.073)	(0.071)
State−national growth, ages 18–25		-0.036		
		(0.051)		
Age			-0.022**	
			(0.009)	
Age^2			9.05×10^{-5}	
			(9.97×10^{-5})	
Fixed-effects				
State	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)				Yes
Fit statistics				
Observations	2,231	1,802	2,231	2,231
R^2	0.01985	0.02504	0.07118	0.10113

Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size: no coefficient significant at 5%.

Absolute mobility relative to the nation

Prolific 2025: support for redistribution on state−national absolute mobility

Dependent Variable:	Support for redistribution		
Spec.:	home FE	+age	+coh.
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)
Variables			
State−national abs. mobility (SD)	-0.124**	-0.025	-0.126*
	(0.047)	(0.064)	(0.068)
Age		-0.027	
		(0.032)	
Age^2		0.0002	
		(0.0003)	
Fixed-effects			
State	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)			Yes
Fit statistics			
Observations	998	998	998
R^2	0.04667	0.04943	0.09092

Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.124	–	–
as % of the young–old gap	39%	–	–

Inequality grown up with and redistribution

Prolific 2025: support for redistribution on the top-10% income share grown up with

Dependent Variable:	concern			
Model:	Top10 avg (1)	Top10 change (2)	avg − nat (3)	change − nat (4)
Variables				
Top-10% share, formative average (SD)	0.265*** (0.023)			
Top-10% share, formative change (SD)		0.091*** (0.029)		
Formative average − national (SD)			-0.041 (0.133)	
Formative change − national (SD)				-0.013 (0.043)
Fixed-effects				
State	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Fit statistics				
Observations	2,078	2,078	2,078	2,078
R^2	0.07168	0.02750	0.02144	0.02121

Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	+0.265	+0.091	–	–
as % of the young–old gap	97%	20%	–	–

Formative-years growth and zero-sum beliefs

Prolific 2025: zero-sum beliefs on home-state formative-years income growth

Dependent Variables:	Rich gain at others' expense				CEO pay at workers' expense	DEI: opportunity trade-off
Spec.:	0–20	18–25	0–20, +age	0–20, +coh.	0–20	
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Variables						
Formative growth, ages 0–20	-0.283***		0.107	0.146**	-0.089*	0.188***
	(0.058)		(0.074)	(0.070)	(0.046)	(0.052)
Formative growth, ages 18–25		0.051				
		(0.031)				
Age			-0.017			
			(0.010)			
Age^2			-1.83×10^{-6}			
			(0.0001)			
Fixed-effects						
Home state	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)				Yes		
Fit statistics						
Observations	2,219	1,790	2,219	2,219	2,206	2,207
R^2	0.03791	0.02769	0.07300	0.09288	0.02284	0.03086

Clustered (Home state) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.151	–	–	+0.078	–	+0.100
as % of the young–old gap	54%	–	–	-28%	–	75%

Absolute mobility and zero-sum beliefs

Prolific 2025: zero-sum beliefs on home-state absolute mobility

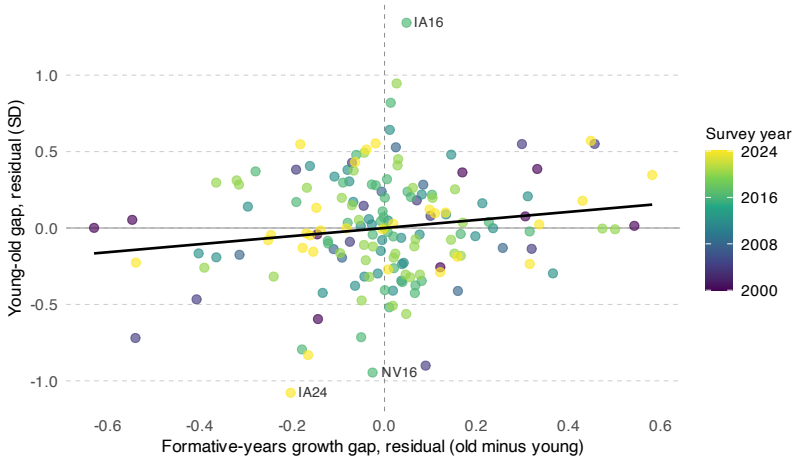
Dependent Variables:	Rich gain at others' expense			CEO pay at workers' expense	DEI: opportunity trade-off
Spec.:	home FE	+age	+coh.	home FE	
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Variables					
Absolute mobility (SD)	-0.146***	-0.025	-0.076	-0.081**	0.006
	(0.039)	(0.082)	(0.211)	(0.031)	(0.027)
Age		-0.018			
		(0.023)			
Age^2		6.06×10^{-5}			
		(0.0002)			
Fixed-effects					
Home state	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)			Yes		
Fit statistics					
Observations	995	995	995	988	992
R^2	0.06725	0.07008	0.09496	0.05722	0.05653

Clustered (Home state) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.146	–	–	−0.080	–
as % of the young–old gap	52%	–	–	108%	–

Formative-years growth gap vs. redistribution gap across states

ANES state × year: young–old redist. gap vs. formative-years growth gap, net of state and year FE



Slope 0.26, r = 0.15, 166 state-years (ANES 2000-2024). State and survey-year fixed effects removed from both ax

Formative-years growth and redistribution

ANES: support for redistribution on own-state formative-years growth

Dependent Variable:	Support for redistribution (VCF0809)			
Model:	0–20 (1)	18–25 (2)	0–20, +age (3)	0–20, +cohort FE (4)
Variables				
Own-state formative growth, ages 0–20	-0.090***		0.013	0.016
	(0.012)		(0.016)	(0.021)
Own-state formative growth, ages 18–25		-0.017***		
		(0.004)		
Age			-0.024***	
			(0.003)	
Age^2			0.0002***	
			(3.4×10^{-5})	
Fixed-effects				
State	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Survey year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)				Yes
Fit statistics				
Observations	36,101	40,784	36,101	36,101
R^2	0.02238	0.01688	0.03462	0.03816
Within R^2	0.00473	0.00073	0.01719	3.44×10^{-5}

Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.081	−0.028	–	–
as % of the young–old gap	33%	9%	–	–

Absolute mobility and redistribution

ANES: support for redistribution on own-state absolute mobility

Dependent Variable:	Support for redistribution (VCF0809)		
Model:	state+yr (1)	+age (2)	+cohort FE (3)
Variables			
Own-state absolute mobility (SD)	-0.095***	-0.003	-0.012
	(0.008)	(0.016)	(0.063)
Age		-0.024***	
		(0.004)	
Age^2		0.0002***	
		(4.11×10^{-5})	
Fixed-effects			
State	Yes	Yes	Yes
Survey year	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)			Yes
Fit statistics			
Observations	30,252	30,252	30,252
R^2	0.02219	0.02505	0.02650
Within R^2	0.00715	0.01006	3.29×10^{-6}

Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.095	–	–
as % of the young–old gap	45%	–	–

Formative-years growth relative to the nation

ANES: support for redistribution on state−national formative growth

Dependent Variable:	Support for redistribution			
Spec.:	0–20	18–25	0–20, +age	0–20, +coh.
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Variables				
State−national growth, ages 0–20	-0.011		0.019	0.016
	(0.040)		(0.024)	(0.021)
State−national growth, ages 18–25		0.009		
		(0.017)		
Age			-0.023***	
			(0.003)	
Age^2			0.0002***	
			(3.42×10^{-5})	
Fixed-effects				
State	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Survey year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)				Yes
Fit statistics				
Observations	36,101	40,784	36,101	36,101
R^2	0.01775	0.01620	0.03461	0.03816

Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size: no coefficient significant at 5%.

Absolute mobility relative to the nation

ANES: support for redistribution on state−national absolute mobility

Dependent Variable:	Support for redistribution		
Spec.:	state+yr	+age	+coh.
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)
Variables			
State−national abs. mobility (SD)	-0.060***	0.010	-0.004
	(0.011)	(0.013)	(0.019)
Age		-0.024***	
		(0.004)	
Age^2		0.0002***	
		(4.08×10^{-5})	
Fixed-effects			
State	Yes	Yes	Yes
Survey year	Yes	Yes	Yes
Birth year (cohort)			Yes
Fit statistics			
Observations	30,252	30,252	30,252
R^2	0.01746	0.02509	0.02650

Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	−0.061	–	–
as % of the young–old gap	18%	–	–

Inequality grown up with and redistribution

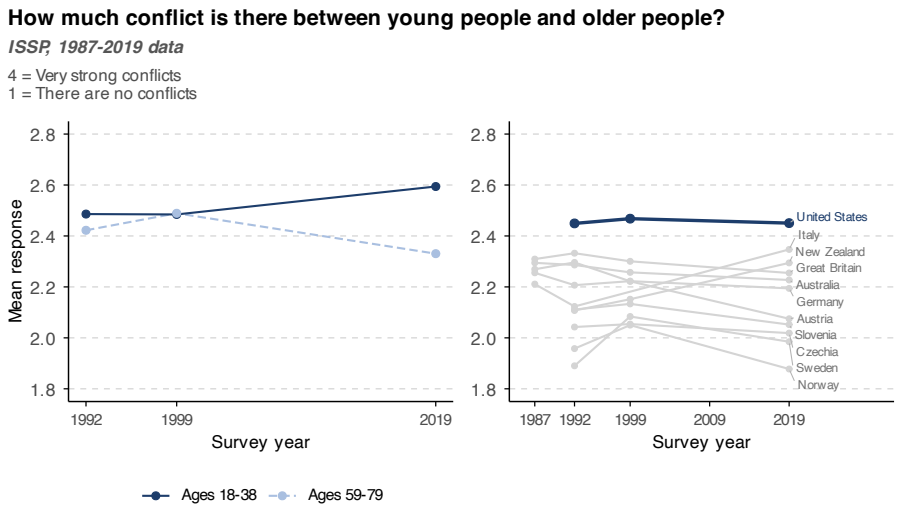
ANES: support for redistribution on the top-10% income share grown up with

Dependent Variable:	Y			
Model:	Top10 avg (1)	Top10 change (2)	avg − nat (3)	change − nat (4)
Variables				
Top-10% share, formative average (SD)	0.075*** (0.011)			
Top-10% share, formative change (SD)		0.079*** (0.008)		
Formative average − national (SD)			0.024 (0.023)	
Formative change − national (SD)				-0.012 (0.010)
Fixed-effects				
State	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Survey year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Fit statistics				
Observations	39,917	39,917	39,917	39,917
R^2	0.02235	0.02252	0.01783	0.01769

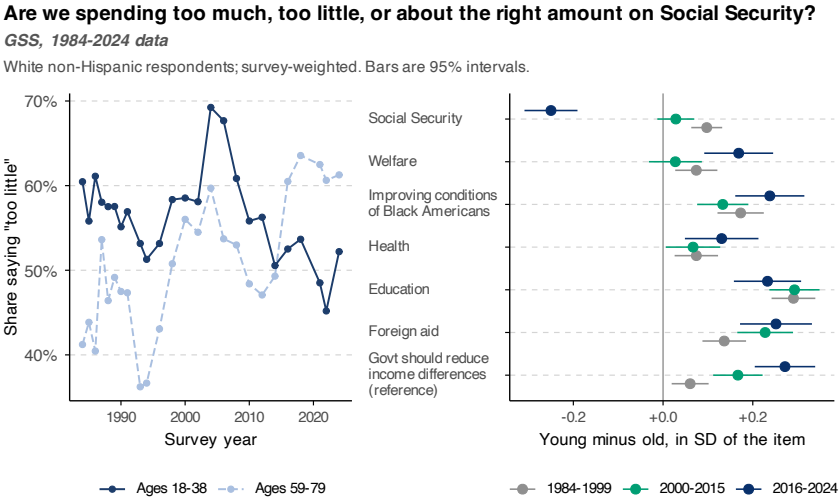
Clustered (State) standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Economic size (significant columns only):	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Per +1 SD of regressor (Δ outcome, SD)	+0.080	+0.080	–	–
as % of the young–old gap	16%	35%	–	–

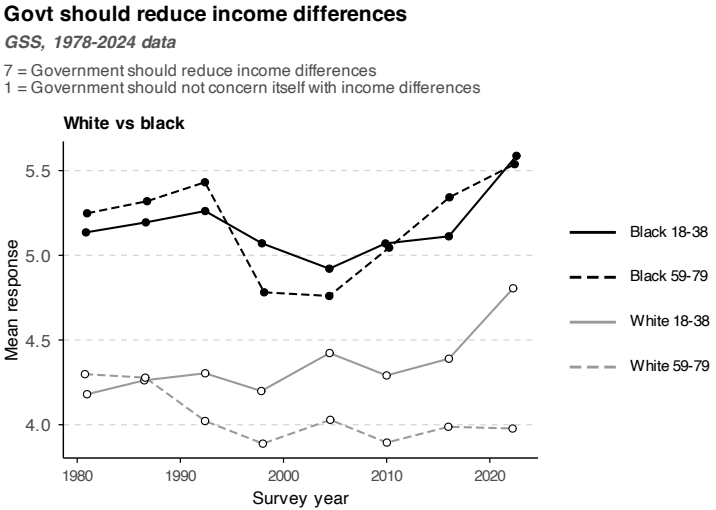
Perceived conflict between young and old



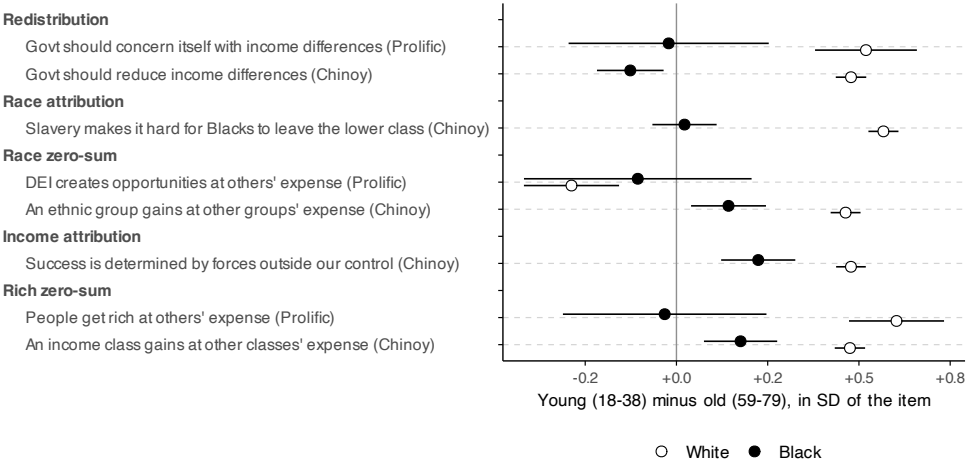
Social Security: the one service where the young want less



The age gradient by race



The age gradient by race



Conclusions

- The US age gap is new.
  - It started emerging in the 80s and widened substantially around 2020–24.
- It is not the economic position of the young, but whether they believe the economic game is zero-sum or rigged.
  - Other academic surveys tend to agree.
- The US age gap is near the top of 91 countries, with the UK and the Nordics.
- Where the young are more zero-sum, they tend to be more pro-redistribution, across and within countries.

Future analysis

- Second survey wave
  - Questions on moral values, govt. trust, religiosity, and race-related beliefs.
  - In-depth measurement and differentiation of zero-sum and attribution beliefs.
  - An information provision or wording experiment generating exogenous belief variation.
- Geographic and micro variation
  - State and local-level age inequality measures: political representation (L2 voter files), policy tilt, real circumstances (housing, employment, etc.)
- Text analysis
  - Extracting zero-sum rich and zero-sum race narratives from Congressional speeches. Manifesto Project for cross-country.

Why is the US unique?

Possibilities:

- Old-age benefits and the political power of the old
- Two-party bundling of cultural and economic positions (majoritarian vs. proportional system)
- Political entrepreneurs (Sanders, Trump)

What explains sharp rise in gap post-2020?

- Prominent billionaires reshaping society (Musk, Bezos)
- Racial justice salience (BLM movement)
- Affordability crisis (inflation, housing) and youth unemployment
- Government debt worries (social security more salient)
- Elderly presidential candidates in 2020 and 2024

References I

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